

EXPERTSPEAK



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How do you use technology in your current setting?

[At the Indian School of Business] We are clearly in the space where we want to use technology to reach to more students at their chosen time, but at a quality that is consistent with ISB standards. With two campuses, we will increasingly have one common course, taught by a faculty on one campus, available on the other campus in real-time, with full participation by the second campus students. This typically is a blend of online education, classroom teaching, and assignments.

What challenges have you faced when trying to integrate technology in the classroom, especially since it's executive education?

In Executive Education in particular, considering the brief window of time learners commit to the program, they find it difficult to read material before they come to ISB. They also do not want to exchange class time for self-learning time as the interaction and discussion process is an important mode of learning. Pedagogy also must be very different for technology based education and sometimes, faculty acceptance of the medium is also a challenge. Investing in capital-intensive technology is tricky because of lower shelf-lives of these solutions. There is somehow a false perception still that technology based learning is sub-standard.

What positive outcomes has technology been responsible for?

Learners come better prepared to class, thus facilitating richer discussion. They are pre-introduced to their classmates (particularly relevant in executive education) so the interaction process is faster and better.

Zeenat then moves on to the "Next Steps" tab, which is auto-populated with points such as "Decrease text-to-illustration ratio in next story," "Model two more inferring questions for students", "Increase rigour for vocabulary", and also gives her links to websites that provide the appropriate resources. With all this data available at a click (and also accessible by the school principal), Zeenat now reviews her lesson plan for the rest of the week on her online teacher calendar. Trying to think of additional support structures for students who are lagging behind, she posts a query on an online bulletin



Students interacting with game elements in a mixed-reality learning environment implemented using motion-capture cameras and projectors

board for primary teachers in her school district. All teaching staff from her school, including the principal, post queries and responses regularly, and she hopes for a few gems from veteran teachers.

Can fantasy be realized?

What we just described are only two means through which technology can be leveraged to significantly improve academic achievement. "Broadcast television is the most accessible and widely used platform for educational content among lower-income children.", says a late 2011 Common Sense Media research study. And the story isn't too different in India in terms of proliferation. The television and direct-to-home satellite networks, due to their high consumer adoption rates, could be a really effective mechanism for delivering high-quality education. It has the potential to not only improve student interest, but also get around the problem of limited classroom time by bringing educational content right into their homes.

An age-old question that continues to haunt educators is "How do I know what my students have understood?" By

using the television as a tool to collect data on students' level of understanding, we can empower our teachers with a real-time view that they may then use to streamline their teaching plans for the subsequent days. Although this scenario may seem very far from reality, the technologies to implement these do exist. Even now, the popular TV show "Sesame Street" delivers educational content via Microsoft's Xbox Kinect consoles.

Another challenge faced by teachers is the extreme diversity of problems they face in class such as motivation/behaviour issues, daily lesson planning, learning disabilities, low attendance, ineffective curriculum, etc. There is no other ecosystem where "the power of the crowd" may be better utilized than in the field of education. The internet is slowly promoting this by helping set-up online professional learning communities (such as www.betterlesson.com and www.learnzillion.com), where teachers working at a particular grade, subject, or locality may come together to share exemplary lesson plans, brainstorm on classroom issues or simply provide solutions. This should significantly speed up the journey a novice teacher has to make to become an expert.

As simple as better school furniture

Adopting technology into teaching can be as simple as using better school furniture. The American School of Bombay, a premier international school in India, uses stools with a curved base that let them rock in any direction without toppling over. The rocking motion of the stools absorbs some of their energy and helps students focus on the lesson rather than disturb other students (*see: Video: HOKKI stools by V/S Furniture*, <http://dg.in/edufurn>). The school also uses sliding



"Rockable" stools help increase student focus in the classroom